

**Caribbean History
May – June 2011**

Question 8

Theme 4 : Metropolitan Movements Towards Emancipation

Imagine that it is 1837 and you are Thomas Harvey, a visiting abolitionist to the Caribbean. Write a letter to the London Times newspaper explaining the reasons why apprentices continue to protest against the Apprenticeship System.

Total 25 marks

write on both sides of the paper and start each answer on a new page.

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#10 Waverly Street
Bamboo Village
Pinedale, WI.

7th, August, 1851.

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Dear Editor,

I am Thomas Harvey, and I am an abolitionist. I am currently visiting the island of Trinidad. While I am here, I am quietly investigating the country's Apprenticeship System. I have also had the opportunity to speak with a few of them ^(the apprentices). In this letter I want to bring to your attention the plight of these people and why they are continuing to protest against this 'apprenticeship' system.

During one of my quiet observations, I've noticed that the apprentices are still being treated ~~un~~ unfairly. They are hardly fed, severely beaten and still treated with utter disrespect. This has shocked me, because in my view they should be treated the opposite of how they are treated now, according to the Apprenticeship System.

I got the opportunity to speak with an apprentice named Gregory. He told me that the Apprenticeship System is merely a cover up for how they are really treated. Their masters keep instilling in them that they will never be really free and working on the plantation is as far as they will get. They are still treated with scorn and disgust. After all their hard work they do each day, they are not even paid or rewarded! It is almost impossible for the apprentices to acquire land to make a home for themselves and their families. They are not encouraged by planters to go off ^{and} pursue their hobbies and earn money, but rather that they ^{be} motivated by their planters to all that they can do for them.

write on both sides of the paper and start each answer on a new page

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they will never be anything more than a field worker, making them inclined to believe that they were born to be slaves and apprentices and they will never be free.

My conversations with the ^{other} apprentices all reflected the same points as my talk with ~~Amy~~ Amy. They all wanted to know if they will continue to protest until they see the new changes made by the Apprenticeship System be awarded to them. They continued to protest against it because they are still treated unfairly. They all dealt with the planters as if they are still slaves under the slave code. They are taught no new trades other than gold work and housework. Sometimes they are beaten and most of them are not fed often. They all agree that the Apprenticeship System is a big cover up and an attempt to hide how they are really treated by the planters. They know that most planters believe that they should still be enslaved as they (^{the planters}) live with the Apprenticeship System. The apprentices are all convinced that the judges in authority are responsible for not investigating the situation or they have no right to protest against the apprenticeship system until justice is served and they can all live happily and peacefully with one another.

Some agree that the two spoken, with 1 believe that they should be totally abolished, and, then by speaking if they want total freedom and the ability to create new lives for themselves I agree with this because I think they should be treated equally and have rights just as we do. Shouldn't they? After all, we're all the same blood, sweat and tears and we are all human.

Verne K. D. 1950: 19

Comments

This question targeted the apprenticeship system. Candidates were asked to explain why the Apprentices continued to protest against the Apprenticeship System.

Statement on overall quality

The quality of this answer was good.

Knowledge and Comprehension

The candidate displayed an acceptable level of knowledge and understanding of the question. There was also a satisfactory explanation as to why the apprentices found the system unacceptable. There was enough to meet the requirements of a level II award.

Use of Knowledge

The candidate failed to explore definite issues, incidents and situations and this weakness reduced the effectiveness of the interpretations presented. The analysis lacked the depth necessary for a mark at the top of the scale.

Enquiry and Communication

Utilising general knowledge but writing skillfully the candidate earned a good mark. This candidate's knowledge base was limited in specific instances.

A better response would, in addition to recognising the fact that the planters had not experienced a change of attitude and therefore did not relax the harsh estate discipline, would have required a greater familiarity with some of these issues, the tendency to reclassify artisans to praedials (field worker) and the constant threat of this form of demotion, the demand that the apprentices work eight hours each day for five days each week, the tendency to feed the apprentices short supplies, the refusal to give apprentices other customary indulgences, the refusal to pay for overtime work and the difficulty the apprentices experienced in purchasing their freedom.